her from playing a more pivotal role in nation-building. She is known for her pioneering work in craft and the performing arts, considered suitable for a woman, but her interests and concerns were so much wider: education, gender equity, labour rights and welfare, the environment.

In her first 40 years until Independence, she was a noted political activist and freedom-fighter, a party organiser, speaker, a champion for social and institutional change at every level. Despite Gandhi's advice to "settle down in a village" and "put her hand to the wheel", she was intrinsically committed to widespread social change. "Classless, cooperative, democratic" socialism and social reform, not craft and khadi, were the core of her being and beliefs.

For a woman who wrote so much (she carried her typewriter with her wherever she went, tapping out her thoughts on train journeys and family holidays), she could be exasperatingly reticent about her own past. Slate talks sensitively regarding the scars of losing not only her beloved father but the family's wealth, and then being left a child widow in her early teens. Later, the failure of her second (love) marriage, and fractured relationship with her son inflicted new wounds. A further blow was not being included in the government post-Independence, despite her huge role in the freedom movement.

Chattopadhyay didn't contrast traditions with modernity. For her, wearing a traditional sari did not mean being wrapped in tradition

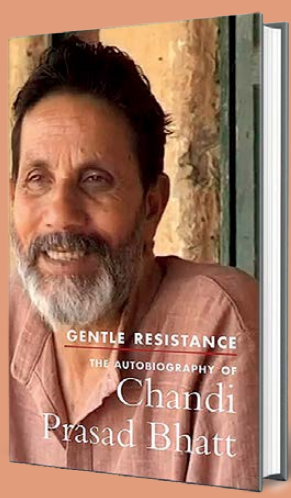
Kamaladevi had culture, intellect, humour, charisma, humanity—and most importantly—a passionate commitment to India, its culture and its people. A capacity for telling the truth often got her into trouble in a political landscape more accustomed to sycophancy. "Where a socialist State is not at the same time liberal and democratic," she wrote, "it is bound to become exploitative and oppressive." Sentences like this could not have made her popular among her erstwhile political comrades, including Nehru and Patel, now national leaders.

Sidelined by the new government, she "left the highway of politics to step into the side lane of constructive work". For the remainder of her life, she would be focused on "field work with the artisans, the artists, those who create and produce that mankind may live and grow, not on bread alone, but on things of beauty which uplift and raise us above the petty things of everyday life".

She also refused to contrast craft traditions with modernity. For her, wearing a traditional sari did not mean being wrapped in tradition. Just as, when need be, she got fellow delegates to cut up their saris to create an Indian national flag to fly at an international conference.

Slate is Professor of History at Carnegie Mellon University and knows contemporary India well. His book resonates on so many levels. When he quotes Kamaladevi's granddaughter Nina saying her grandmother smelt of sandalwood, I got a ghostly whiff of her distinctive scent—sandalwood mixed with the rose or jasmine flowers she always wore in her hair. I wish that more of Kamaladevi's essence and the reason and humanity that were her guiding principles still irradiated our lives. ■

–Laila Tyabji



GENTLE RESISTANCE
The Autobiography of Chandi Prasad Bhatt
by Chandi Prasad Bhatt
Translated by Samir Banerjee
PERMANENT BLACK
₹895; 368 pages

timber was allocated to Symonds, which made sports goods in Allahabad.

Chipko—hugging a tree to protect it—was a 'gentle resistance' to contractors from Symonds. In December 1973, "the contractor and his workers returned with all their equipment...our movement had met its first success." In 1974, in the nearby Reni forests, women confronted work-gangs. "We have come here to take bullets on our chests and axes on our backs—you will have to cut us down first, then cut the trees." Not a tree was felled.

Now highly visible, by 1977, the movement had negotiated a ban on official felling in the Alaknanda Valley. There have been echoes of the movement in Kumaon and Garhwal, but the essence is unchanged—the government owns the forests, the people mere petitioners.

Meanwhile, concerns have shifted. Access to forest produce is no longer the major issue, rather the key role Himalayan forests play in environmental stability. Locals are the immediate victims of Himalayan disasters, but events like the 2013 Kedarnath flood impacts the national consciousness, with threats of worse to come. Confrontation, even of the gentle kind, won't work. The stakeholders are too many, the stakes too large. Preserving the Himalayan forests will require consultative, non-hierarchical processes, from Kashmir to Arunachal. ■

–Mohit Satyanand

In spite of the movement's success, the essence is unchanged—the government owns the forests, the people mere petitioners